

Generalized Gamma Convolution Laws from Continuous Branching Processes

Anita Behme (TU Dresden), Wissem Jedidi (Tunis el Manar, KSU)

April 19, 2026

Continuous-State Branching Processes on $[0, \infty)$

- $(X_t)_{t \geq 0} = \text{CSBP}$ if $\mathbb{P}_{x+y}(X_t \in \cdot) = \mathbb{P}_x(X_t \in \cdot) * \mathbb{P}_y(X_t \in \cdot)$, $x, y, t \geq 0$.

- Chapman–Kolmogorov:

$$\mathbb{E}_x[e^{-\lambda X_t}] = e^{-x u_t(\lambda)}, \quad \lambda \geq 0 \implies u_t(u_s(\lambda)) = u_{t+s}(\lambda).$$

- Regularity condition and branching mechanism (Biggins, Bingham, Grey, Silverstein, 70–80's):

$$\lim_{t \rightarrow 0} \frac{u_t(\lambda) - \lambda}{t} = c(\lambda) \implies u_0(\lambda) = \lambda, \quad \frac{\partial}{\partial t} u_t(\lambda) = \mathbf{c}(u_t(\lambda))$$

$$\mathbf{c}(\lambda) = \alpha + \beta\lambda - \gamma\lambda^2 + \int_{(0, \infty)} (1 - e^{-\lambda x} - \lambda x e^{-x}) Q(dx).$$

$\alpha, \gamma \geq 0$, $\beta \in \mathbb{R}$, $Q = \text{Lévy measure}$.

Motivation: Branching Equation

Supercritical case: $\gamma = 0$ and $c'(0+) \in (0, \infty)$.

$$c(\lambda) = k + \delta\lambda + \int_{(0,\infty)} (1 - e^{-\lambda x}) Q(x) dx \in \mathcal{BF}.$$

- The Lamperti transform of $(X_t)_{t \geq 0}$ involves

$(Y_t)_{t \geq 0}$ = subordinator with Bernstein function c

- (Biggins, Bingham, Grey 70–80's): $\exists$ a normalization $\eta(t)$ s.t.
 $e^{-\eta(t)} X_t =$ converging positive martingale, hence

$$W_t = \eta(t) X_t \xrightarrow{a.s.} W_\infty \sim \text{ID}(\mathbb{R}_+).$$

- The branching equation: the Bernstein function w of W_∞ satisfies

$$w(0) = 0, \quad \lambda w'(\lambda) = c(w(\lambda)), \quad \lambda \geq 0 \quad (\mathbf{BE}).$$

Pakes' Conjecture (2018)

Pakes' conjecture: $W_\infty \sim \text{BO or GGC} \iff w \in \mathcal{CBF} \text{ or } \mathcal{TBF}$.

The central equation is

$$\lambda w'(\lambda) = c(w(\lambda)), \quad \lambda \geq 0 \quad (\text{BE}).$$

Key quantity: $\tau(\lambda) = \int_0^\lambda \left(\frac{1}{c(x)} - \frac{1}{x} \right) dx, \quad c \in \mathcal{BF}$.

Pakes (2018): under a log-moment condition for Q ,

- $c \in \mathcal{SB} \iff \tau(\lambda), \lambda\tau'(\lambda) \in \mathcal{BF} \implies w \in \mathcal{SB}$.
- $c \in \mathcal{CBF} \iff \tau \in \mathcal{TBF}$.

Motivation by Examples

i	$c_i(\lambda)$	$\tau_i(\lambda)$	$w_i(\lambda)$	$w_i \in \mathcal{TB}\mathcal{F}$?
1	$1 - e^{-\lambda}$	$\log\left(\frac{e^\lambda - 1}{\lambda}\right)$	$\log(1 + \lambda)$	✓
2	$\alpha\lambda$	$\nexists$	λ^α	✓ for $\alpha \in (0, 1]$
3	$\delta(\lambda + 1 - (1 + \lambda)^{1-\frac{1}{\delta}})$	$\log\left(\frac{(1+\lambda)^{1/\delta} - 1}{\lambda}\right)$	$(1 + \lambda)^\delta - 1$	✓ for $\delta \in (0, 1]$
4	$\frac{\lambda}{1+\lambda}$	λ	Lambert func.	✓

Note that

- Concavity is necessary for Bernstein structure for w . Solutions may exist **outside** $\mathcal{BF}$:

$$c_2(\lambda) = \alpha\lambda \implies w_2 \text{ is convex if } \alpha > 1.$$

- The **Lambert function** w_4 has no closed form, it satisfies

$$w_4(\lambda) = \lambda e^{-w_4(\lambda)} \in \mathcal{TB}\mathcal{F} \quad (\text{Pakes 2011}).$$

Intuition and approach to solve Pakes' conjecture

- Our analysis is performed **WITHOUT** relying on branching process arguments. It illustrates that the *generalized Lambert functions* solutions of

$$w(\lambda)e^{\tau(w(\lambda))} = \lambda$$

are often **Thorin Bernstein functions**.

- From last tabular: the condition $c'(0) \leq 1$ appears essential !!
- $c \in \mathcal{CBF} \implies$ there is no solution w of **(BE)** in $\mathcal{CBF} \setminus \mathcal{TBF}$.
- Another Key quantity is the inverse function $\Psi = w^{-1}$:

$$\mathbf{(BE)} \iff \Psi(\lambda) = \Psi'(\lambda) c(\lambda).$$

When is Ψ a "nice" Lévy-Laplace exponent of the Spectrally Negative type ?

- **Important fact:**

$$\theta > 1 \implies c_\theta(x) := \theta x^{1-\frac{1}{\theta}} c(x^{\frac{1}{\theta}}) \in \mathcal{BF} \text{ (} \in \mathcal{CBF} \text{ if } \theta \geq 2 \text{)}.$$

Solutions for the (BE)

$$\lambda w'(\lambda) = c(w(\lambda)), \quad c(\lambda) = k + \delta\lambda + \int_{(0,\infty)} (1 - e^{-\lambda x}) Q(x) dx \quad \textbf{(BE)}.$$

$$c'(0+) = 1 \quad \text{and} \quad \int_1^\infty x \log x Q(dx) < \infty \quad \textbf{(LMC)}.$$

Theorem 1 (existence and unicity result):

- 1) $c(0) = 0 \iff \exists w$ solution of **(BE)** unique up to scaling: $w(\rho\lambda)$, $\rho > 0$.
- 2) $c'(0+) \leq 1 = \delta = 1 \iff c(\lambda) = \lambda$, and $w(\lambda) = \rho\lambda$, $\lambda \geq 0$, for some $\rho > 0$.
- 3) $c'(0+) \leq 1$, $\delta < 1 \iff w$ concave $\iff w(\lambda) = \int_0^\infty (1 - e^{-\lambda x}) \frac{k(x)}{x} dx$, $k \searrow$.
- 4) $w'(0+) = \begin{cases} \infty, & \text{if } c'(0+) < 1; \\ 1, & \text{if } \textbf{(LMC)} \text{ holds.} \end{cases}$
- 5) **(LMC)** $\iff \tau(\lambda) = \int_0^\lambda \left(\frac{1}{c(x)} - \frac{1}{x} \right) dx \in [0, \infty)$, $\forall \lambda \geq 0 \implies w \in \mathcal{SB}$ and

$$w_*(\lambda) := \frac{\lambda}{w(\lambda)} = e^{\tau(w(\lambda))} \quad (\text{generalized Lambert functions}).$$

Reminder on ID

- $f \in \mathcal{CM} \iff (-1)^k f^{(k)}(\lambda) \geq 0 \xLeftrightarrow{\text{Bernstein}} f(\lambda) = \int_{[0,\infty)} e^{-\lambda x} \mu(dx), \lambda > 0.$

- $\phi \in \mathcal{BF} \iff \phi \geq 0, \phi' \in \mathcal{CM}, \text{ i.e.}$

$$\phi(\lambda) = a + b\lambda + \int_{(0,\infty)} (1 - e^{-\lambda x}) \pi(dx), \quad \lambda \geq 0, \quad (a, b \geq 0).$$

- Lévy exponent

$$\Psi(u) = iud - \frac{c^2 u^2}{2} + \int_{\mathbb{R} \setminus \{0\}} (e^{iux} - 1 - iuh(x)) \pi(dx), \quad u \in \mathbb{R}.$$

- Lévy Processes: $t > s \geq 0 \implies Z_t - Z_s \perp\!\!\!\perp \mathcal{F}_s$ and $Z_t - Z_s \stackrel{d}{=} Z_{t-s}.$

- Subordinator: $\eta_t =$ nondecreasing Lévy process.

- Lévy–Khintchine Formulae: $\mathbb{E}[e^{iuZ_t}] = e^{t\Psi(u)}, \quad \mathbb{E}[e^{-\lambda\eta_t}] = e^{-t\phi(\lambda)}.$

- Infinite divisibility: $X \sim \text{ID}(\mathbb{R})$ (resp $\text{ID}(\mathbb{R}_+)$) $\iff X \stackrel{d}{=} Z_1$ (resp $X \stackrel{d}{=} \eta_1$).

Important Subclasses of $\mathcal{BF}$

- Jurek Bernstein functions ($\mathcal{JBF}$): $\frac{\pi(dx)}{dx} \searrow$.
- Special Bernstein functions ($\mathcal{SB}$): ϕ and $\phi_*(\lambda) = \frac{\lambda}{\phi(\lambda)} \in \mathcal{BF}$.
- Complete Bernstein functions of order $a > -1$ ($\mathcal{CBF}_a$):

$$\phi \in \mathcal{BF} \text{ and } \frac{\pi(dx)}{dx} = x^{a-1} \int_{(0,\infty)} e^{-x u} \Delta(du).$$

Equivalently, $\phi \geq 0$ and $\phi' \in \mathcal{S}_a = \{b + \int_{(0,\infty)} \frac{1}{(\lambda+u)^a} \Delta(du)\}$.

Examples: $\alpha \in (0, 1) \implies \lambda^\alpha \in \mathcal{CBF}_{-\alpha}$, $\lambda^\alpha / (1 + \lambda^\alpha) \in \mathcal{CBF}_\alpha$.

- Complete Bernstein functions ($\mathcal{CBF} \subset \mathcal{SB}$):

$$\mathcal{CBF} = \mathcal{CBF}_1 \longleftrightarrow \text{BO} = \overline{\bigcap \text{mixtures of exponentials}}.$$

- Thorin Bernstein functions ($\mathcal{TBF}$):

$$\mathcal{TBF} = \mathcal{CBF}_0 \longleftrightarrow \text{GGC} = \overline{\bigcap \text{mixture of gamma distributions}}.$$

Lévy–Laplace exponents

- Lévy–Laplace exponents $(\mathcal{LE}) \longleftrightarrow \text{SPLN}$:

$$\psi(\lambda) = a + b\lambda + c\lambda^2 + \int_{(0,\infty)} (e^{-\lambda x} - 1 + \lambda x)\pi(dx), \quad \lambda \geq 0,$$

Proposition 1 (Complement to Bertoin, Roynette and M. Yor 2004): Let

$\Psi : [0, \infty) \rightarrow [0, \infty)$ continuous, differentiable on $(0, \infty)$ s.t. $\Psi(0) = 0$. Define

$$\phi := \Psi^{-1}, \quad \phi_*(\lambda) = \lambda/\phi(\lambda) \text{ and } \Psi^*(\lambda) := \lambda\phi_*(\lambda) = \lambda^2/\phi(\lambda).$$

1) The following assertions are equivalent

- (i) $\Psi \in \mathcal{LE}$;
- (ii) $\phi \in \mathcal{BF}$, and $\phi_* = g(\phi)$, for some $g \in \mathcal{JBF}$;
- (iii) ϕ is differentiable on $(0, \infty)$ and $1/\phi' = h(\phi)$, for some $h \in \mathcal{BF}$.

2) Under any of the latter, the following holds:

- (i) $\phi \in \mathcal{SB}$ and $1/(\phi')^2 \in \mathcal{BF}$;
- (ii) $\Psi' \in \mathcal{SB} \implies \phi^2 \in \mathcal{LE}$;
- (iii) The potential density of ϕ is convex $\iff \phi_* \in \mathcal{JBF} \iff \Psi^* \in \mathcal{LE}$.

Important Subclasses of $\mathcal{LE}$

- Complete Lévy-Laplace exponents of order $a > -2$ ($\mathcal{CLE}_a$):

$$\psi \in \mathcal{LE} \text{ and } \frac{\pi(dx)}{dx} = x^{a-2} \int_{(0,\infty)} e^{-x \cdot u} \Delta(du).$$

Equivalently, $\psi \geq 0$ and $\psi' \in \mathcal{CBF}_a$.

Proposition 2: We assume the formalism of Proposition 1.

- 1) The following assertions are equivalent:

- (i) $\Psi \in \mathcal{CLE}_2$;
- (ii) $\phi \in \mathcal{CBF}$ and $\phi_* = g(\phi)$, with some $g \in \mathcal{CBF}$ (hence $\Psi^* \in \mathcal{CLE}_2$);
- (iii) ϕ solves the differential equation $1/\phi' = h(\phi)$, with some $h \in \mathcal{CBF}_2$.

- 2) We have (i) $\implies$ (ii) $\iff$ (iii) $\implies$ (iv):

- (i) $\lambda \mapsto \Psi(\lambda)/\lambda \in \mathcal{TBf}$;
- (ii) $\Psi \in \mathcal{CLE}_1$;
- (iii) $\phi' = s(\phi)$, for some $s \in \mathcal{S}_1$;
- (iv) $\phi \in \mathcal{TBf}$, $\phi^2 \in \mathcal{CLE}_1$ and $\phi_*^2 \in \mathcal{CBF}$.

- 3) If $\Psi \in \mathcal{CLE}_0$ (respectively $\mathcal{CLE}_1$), then $1/(\phi')^2 \in \mathcal{TBf}$ (respectively $\mathcal{CBF}$).

Infinite Divisibility Consequences

Corollary 1: Assume $\mathbf{c}'(\mathbf{0}+) \leq \mathbf{1}$.

1) We have

$$\lambda \mapsto e^{-t w(\lambda)}, \quad e^{-t \lambda w'(\lambda)}, \quad \left(\frac{w(\lambda)}{\lambda} \right)^t, \quad (w'(\lambda))^t \in \mathcal{CM}, \quad t \geq 0, \quad (\text{IDW})$$

and

$$\psi(\lambda) := \lambda w(\lambda) \in \mathcal{LE} \text{ and } \varphi := \psi^{-1} \in \mathcal{SB}$$

satisfies the conjugacy equations

$$\lambda = \varphi w(\varphi), \quad \text{and} \quad \frac{1}{(\varphi')^2} = (w + c \circ w)^2(\varphi) \in \mathcal{BF}.$$

Stochastic interpretations for (IDW) are too long to be developed here!.

2) If in addition **(LMC)** holds, then

$$\Psi = w^{-1} \in \mathcal{LE} \iff e^\tau \in \mathcal{JBF} \iff e^{\tau(\lambda)}(1 + \lambda \tau'(\lambda)) \in \mathcal{BF}.$$

Answers to Pakes' Conjecture: $W_\infty \sim \text{GGC}$

$$\theta > 1 \implies c_\theta(x) := \theta x^{1-\frac{1}{\theta}} c(x^{\frac{1}{\theta}}) \in \mathcal{BF} \text{ (} \in \mathcal{CBF} \text{ if } \theta \geq 2 \text{)}$$

$$c'_\theta(0+) = \theta c'(0+), \quad \text{and} \quad \delta_\theta = \text{drift term of } c_\theta = \theta \delta.$$

Corollary 2 (Composition with power functions) Assume $c'(0+) \leq 1$.

- 1) For all $\sigma > 0$ and $\theta > 1$, the function $w_\sigma(\lambda) := w(\lambda^\sigma)$ and $w^\theta(\lambda)$ are the solution of

$$\lambda w'_\sigma(\lambda) = \sigma c(w_\sigma(\lambda)) \quad \text{and} \quad \lambda (w^\theta)'(\lambda) = c_\theta(w^\theta(\lambda)), \quad \lambda > 0.$$

- 2) If $\sigma, \theta \leq 1/c'(0+)$, and if c replaced by the functions $\sigma \times c$ and c_θ respectively, then w_σ and w^θ satisfy 1) of Corollary 1. Moreover, if

$$\sigma = \theta = \frac{1}{c'(0+)} \quad \text{and} \quad \int_1^\infty x \log x Q(dx) < \infty,$$

they satisfy 2) of Corollary 1.

Answers to Pakes' Conjecture: $W_\infty \sim \text{GGC}$

Theorem 1: Let $a = c'(0+)$. Assume $a < \frac{1}{2}$, or $a = \frac{1}{2}$ and **(LMC)**. Then

$$w \in \mathcal{CBF}_a \text{ (i.e. Lévy density } = x^{a-1} l(x), l \in \mathcal{CM}) \implies w \in \mathcal{TSF}$$

Theorem 2: Assume $c'(0+) \leq 1$ and recall $\Psi = w^{-1}$. Then

1) $c \in \mathcal{CBF} \iff \tau' \in \mathcal{S}_1$, and under (LMC), $c \in \mathcal{CBF} \iff \tau \in \mathcal{TSF}$.

2) If $c \in \mathcal{CBF}$ and, either $c'(0+) < 1$ or **(LMC)**. Then

$$\delta \in [1/2, 1) \iff \Psi \in \mathcal{CL}\mathcal{E}_2 \text{ (i.e. } \Psi \in \mathcal{LE} \text{ and its Lévy density } \in \mathcal{CM}).$$

Under the latter $w \in \mathcal{TSF}$.

Theorem 3: Assume $c \in \mathcal{BF}$ and **one** of the following

$$c'(0+) < \min\left(\frac{1}{2}, 2\delta\right), \text{ and } \theta \in \left[\max\left(\frac{1}{2\delta}, 2\right), \frac{1}{c'(0+)}\right),$$

$$c'(0+) \leq \frac{1}{2}, \int_1^\infty x \log x Q(dx) < \infty, \text{ and } \theta = \frac{1}{c'(0+)}.$$

Then $\Psi(\lambda^{1/\theta}) \in \mathcal{CL}\mathcal{E}_2$, $w^\theta \in \mathcal{TSF}$ and $w^\varkappa \in \mathcal{CBF}$ for all $0 < \varkappa \leq \theta \implies w \in \mathcal{TSF}$

Example: Perturbing the Lambert function

Solving **(BE)** with $c(\lambda) = \delta\lambda + \gamma \frac{\lambda}{1+\lambda}$, $\delta, \gamma > 0$, we obtain

$$\Psi(\lambda) = w^{-1}(\lambda) = \lambda\varphi(\lambda), \quad \varphi(\lambda) = \lambda^{\frac{1}{\delta+\gamma}-1} (\delta\lambda + \delta + \gamma)^{\frac{\gamma}{\delta(\delta+\gamma)}}, \quad \lambda \geq 0.$$

We deduce that

$$\delta + \gamma = c'(0+) \leq 1 \quad \text{and} \quad \frac{1}{2} \leq \delta < 1 \iff g \in \mathcal{CBF} \iff \Psi \in \mathcal{CLE}_2,$$

$$\textbf{(LMC)} \iff \delta + \gamma = 1 \iff \Psi(\lambda) = \lambda (\delta\lambda + 1)^{\frac{1}{\delta}-1}.$$

With $\alpha = \frac{1}{\delta} - 1 \in (0, 1]$, $c_\alpha = \frac{\alpha}{(1+\alpha)^\alpha \Gamma(1-\alpha)}$,

$$\Psi(\lambda) = \lambda + \begin{cases} \frac{\lambda^2}{2}, & \text{if } \delta = \frac{1}{2} \\ c_\alpha \int_0^\infty (e^{-\lambda x} - 1 + \lambda x) e^{-x} \frac{\alpha + 1 + x}{x^{\alpha+2}} dx, & \text{if } \frac{1}{2} < \delta < 1. \end{cases}$$

- $\delta = 1/2 \implies w(\lambda) = \Psi^{-1}(\lambda) = 2(\sqrt{1+\lambda}) - 1 \in \mathcal{TF}$.
- $1/2 < \delta < 1 \xrightarrow{\text{Theorem 3}} w = \Psi^{-1} \in \mathcal{TF}$ but is not explicit!

Main Contributions and Extensions

- 1 Existence and uniqueness of Bernstein solutions.
- 2 Sharp criteria for complete Bernstein structure.
- 3 New Thorin Bernstein constructions.
- 4 Stability under powers and transformations.
- 5 New links between CBP equations and GGC laws: $W_\infty \sim \text{GGC}$
- 6 Extend the study for $c \in \mathcal{LE}$.

Dziękuję!, Thank You!

Selected References



L. Bondesson, *Generalized Gamma Convolutions and Related Classes of Distributions and Densities*, Springer, 1992.



R. Schilling, R. Song, Z. Vondraček, *Bernstein Functions*, 2nd edition, De Gruyter, 2012.



A. G. Pakes, On generalized gamma convolutions and related classes of laws.



K. Sato, *Lévy Processes and Infinitely Divisible Distributions*, Cambridge University Press, 1999.



O. Thorin, Generalized gamma convolutions.



J. Bertoin, *Lévy Processes*, Cambridge University Press, 1996.